

Imani Finkley

<https://imanif.github.io/> | ifinkley@uw.edu

EDUCATION

University of Washington Seattle, WA	Expected June 2030
Ph.D. Information Science Concentration: Data Science <i>Advisor:</i> Melanie Walsh	
Cornell University Ithaca, NY	2020-2024
B.A. Literatures in English, Summa Cum Laude	
<i>Honors Thesis:</i> “By AI: Authorship, Literature, and Large Language Models”	
Danish Institute for Study Abroad Copenhagen, Denmark	Jan 2023-May 2023
Core Program: Game Development	

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Visiting AI Researcher <i>Meta FAIR</i> Seattle, WA	Incoming Sep 2026
Fellow in the 2026-27 Meta AI Mentorship Program	
Graduate Research Assistant <i>University of Washington</i> Seattle, WA	Jun 2026-Present
- Advised by Pelle Tracy and Jason Young in the University of Washington Information School - Conducting semi-structured interviews Washington library professionals on social service programming for communities in housing crisis	
Graduate Research Assistant <i>University of Washington</i> Seattle, WA	Jun 2026-Present
Technical support for 4 5-person research teams as part of the 2026 Humanities Data Science Summer Institute	
Research Fellow <i>University of Maryland</i> College Park, MD	Aug 2024-Aug 2025
- Advised by Naomi Feldman as 2024-25 Baggett Fellow in the University of Maryland Department of Linguistics - Constructed dataset of 800 LLM-generated texts for prompt engineering analysis and copyright law applications - Code data processing and feature representation extraction for computational models in speech perception	
Undergraduate Honors Candidate <i>Cornell University</i> Ithaca, NY	Aug 2023-May 2024
- Advised by Jane Juffer and Matthew Wilkens - Analyzed history of literary canon and the tradition of authorship in discussion with literary works produced by generative AI and large language models by applying literary and media theory concepts - Studied OpenAI’s GPT 3.5 UI alongside university policy and social opinion on generative-AI authorship	
Visiting NLP Researcher <i>Johns Hopkins University</i> Le Mans, France	Jun 2023-Aug 2023
- Participant in 2023 Jelinek Summer Workshop for Speech and Language Technology (JSALT) at the Laboratoire Informatique du Mans (LIUM) in Le Mans, France - Worked under Ehsan Variiani, Lucas Ondel-Yang, Ke Wu, and Sanjeev Khudanpur - Design functions for Lattice-based Speech Transducer PyTorch library to demonstrate the benefits of weighted finite state transducers with end-to-end pipelines with real-use speech processing applications - Maintain comparable functionality and reported 32% improvement in system usage compared to former versions	
Computer Vision Researcher <i>Brown University</i> Providence, RI	Jun 2022-Aug 2022
- Advised by Daniel Ritchie - Design machine learning model for language-based image-to-image domain translation - Finetune image-to-image translation pix2pix model architecture and pre-trained text-image embedding model	
Undergraduate Researcher <i>Brown University</i> Providence, RI (Remote)	Jan 2022-May 2022
- Mentored by Srinath Sridhar in exploreCSR: Socially Responsible AI for Computational Creativity program - Constructed 1600-image dataset using OpenCV methods for model training, testing, and validation - Finetuned cycleGAN model architecture for image translation of video game shots to photorealistic domain	
Undergraduate Research Assistant <i>Cornell University</i> Ithaca, NY (Remote)	Feb 2021-Sep 2021
Analyze relevant literature and computational sustainable methodologies surrounding water resource management and planning to assist Patrick Reed in The Reed Research Group	

PUBLICATIONS & PRESENTATIONS

Imani Finkley, Neel Gupta, Rachel Buurma, and Melanie Walsh. 2026. Fictional Machines: Fiction Theory for Language Models. Under Review at EMNLP 2026.

Imani Finkley, Yulia Tsvetkov, and Melanie Walsh. 2026. I, AI: Performing Personhood in AI Autobiographies. Under Review at AIES 2026.

Joanna Mendy, Jayden Cowley, **Imani Finkley**, Mads Eggerding, Ali Durran, Danielle Lee Tomson, Michael Grass, Cullen White, Emma Spiro, and Kate Starbird. 2026. A failure to communicate: Declining judicial trust and a new approach to institutional communication. [Center for the Informed Public Blog](#).

Imani Finkley, Yuanxi Li, and Melanie Walsh. 2026. Neutrality Bites: Gender Representation in AI-Generated Animal Stories. *ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency (FAccT '26)*, Montreal, Canada. [DOI](#), [arXiv](#).

Imani Finkley. 2026. AI Autobios: User-Targeted Stories about AI's 'Self.' *Intelligence & Imitation: Workshop on Humanities for Artificial Intelligence*, Baltimore, MD.

Imani Finkley. 2024. By AI: Authorship, Literature, and Large Language Models. *Humanities Scholar Program Spring Research Conference*, Ithaca, NY, USA. Presentation.

Imani Finkley. 2024. Literature in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction. *Cornell University Department of Comparative Literature Theory Colloquium*, Ithaca, NY, USA. Presentation.

Lucas Ondel-Yang, Ehsan Variiani, Ke Wu, **Imani Finkley**, et al. 2023. Final: Finite State Methods with Modern Neural Architectures for Speech Applications and Beyond. *Jelinek Summer Workshop for Speech and Language Technology (JSALT)*, Le Mans, France. [Presentation](#) (1:23:52-1:31:10).

Imani Finkley and Daniel Ritchie. 2022. Language-Based Material Manipulation for Transforming Sketches into Images. *The Leadership Alliance National Conference*, Hartford, CT, USA. Poster.

Imani Finkley. 2022. Realizing the *Forbidden West*: Translating Gameplay into Hyper-realistic Action Shots. *Brown University Computer Science Undergraduate Research Symposium*, Providence, RI, USA. Poster.

TEACHING & COMMUNITY SERVICE

Extension Lecturer & Course Developer | *University of Washington* | Seattle, WA **Sep 2025-Nov 2025**

- Co-instruct 3 3-hour sessions for UW Continuum College Digital Skills Fundamentals (DSKILFN N300 A)
- Develop curriculum and lesson plans for ~100 international Thai high school students to teach AI ethics and digital citizenship

ROOTS Program Mentor | *BLACKIVY Foundation* | Remote **Aug 2025-Nov 2025**

- Support 1 rising Black high school senior through the college application process
- Meet biweekly to complete weekly assignments, including drafting and revising personal statement

Workshop Facilitator | *University of Maryland* | College Park, MD **Nov 2024-May 2025**

- Volunteer facilitator for creative computing workshops with the University of Maryland African American Digital & Experimental Humanities (AADHum) Lab and Prince George's County Teen Action Group (TAG)
- Taught 20 Latinx high school students how to program a wearable tech product in Python in Mu Editor

Teaching Assistant | *Cornell University* | Ithaca, NY **Jan 2024-May 2024**

- Advise students in developing experiments, data collection, and implementing advanced NLP systems
- Grade projects and host biweekly 1-hour office hours for 15-student seminar course, Advanced NLP for Humanities Research (INFO 4940)

Underrepresented Minorities in Computing (URMC) Mentor | *Cornell University* | Ithaca, NY **Jan 2022-May 2024**

- Provide tools, resources, and plans for social, academic, and professional development/opportunities for 2 international students in the Ann S. Bowers College of Computing and Information Science

Course Consultant | *Cornell University* | Ithaca, NY **Jan 2022-May 2022**

- Lead weekly 50-minute discussion sections to 20 students to review their understanding of discrete mathematics
- Grade homework and exams at least once a week in 2-hour sessions for a roughly 280-student course (CS2800)

LEADERSHIP EXPERIENCE

Underrepresented Minorities in Computing | *Cornell University* | *President* **Dec 2021-Dec 2022**

- Preside over weekly 30-person executive board, oversee the activities of standing committees, and implement technical outreach community support initiatives for 80 Black, Latinx, & Indigenous undergraduate members
- Maintain relationships with 10 existing corporate sponsors and established new relationships with 6 corporations

Cornell Data Science | Cornell University | [Cornell Bias Lab](#) *Project Manager*

Sep 2022-Dec 2022

- Create and manage project plans that align corporate sponsor and 5-person team goals that explore identity biases with(in) machine learning and artificially intelligent systems
- Present findings on 3 commercial machine translation models in “Bias in Translation” project

HONORS & AWARDS

GSEE Graduate Excellence Award | University of Washington | February 2025

Nancy J. Gershenfeld Endowed Fellowship in Special Librarianship | University of Washington | February 2025

Baggett Fellowship | University of Maryland | July 2024

2024 Outstanding Researcher Award Honorable Mention | Computing Research Association | December 2023

Sphinx Head Honor Society | Cornell University

2023 Joseph E. Connolly '72 Memorial Prize | Cornell University | May 2023

2022 Dean's List Award for Academic Excellence | Cornell University | December 2022

2022 CMD-IT/ACM Richard Tapia Conference Scholarship | Cornell University | September 2022

2021 Grace Hopper Celebration of Women in Computing Conference Scholarship | Cornell University | August 2021